Reflection Portfolio

Student Name: Olive Edeko
Student ID Number: 21381813
Module: MNA1169
Word Count: 4,091

Reflection 1: Dual process model

I was first introduced to the dual process model briefly during an ‘Intermediate Microeconomics’ module I did during the final year of my bachelors degree. The model was introduced as one of the many concepts of behavioural economics and rational choice theory. The model was introduced as two different systems, system 1 and system 2, whose interactions determine how we think, make judgments and act. With system 1 being automatic, requiring little effort and system 2 being more measured and deliberate. This was the extent of my knowledge on the dual system model.

I was then reintroduced to the model in much more depth during this semester's ‘Strategic Thinking’ module. During this module I was able to develop my knowledge on the dual process model as a concept. Following my first introduction to the model, it wasn’t something I thought of at all but following my reintroduction to the model during this semester I have become aware of the model in my everyday life and decision making process.

My first instance of reflecting on the dual process model as part of my decision making process came a few months ago. I was driving to the carpark I usually park my car at before walking to the bus depot and getting the bus to Dublin for school. At the time I had parked my car it was 11.48 am, giving me ample time to make the 8 minute walk to the bus depot and get on the 12 o’clock bus. I then realised that I had left my wallet with my leap card in it at home, the bus only takes leap cards or cash and therefore I had no way of getting on that bus and to school.

My first thought was to go back and get my leap card yet I spent over 3 minutes wasting time, thinking of other ways I could get on the bus even though I knew deep down that it wasn’t possible. Eventually after 3 minutes of deliberation, I followed my first instinct and went home to get my leapcard. I ended up having to park my car at DKIT and get the bus at the last collection point before it reaches the motorway.

When reflecting on this event, what stood out to me is the knowledge that I found it hard to go with my automatic reaction (system 1) and took a few minutes to assess the situation (system 2) which eventually led me back to what my initial reaction was anyways. When I look back, it seems to me that what I should have done was clear and obvious. So, why did I reject the decision that first came to me? I felt like I could not rely on my instinct. This made me take a deeper look at my attitude and feelings towards decision making as a whole.

The idea that one should think thoroughly before making decisions is a widespread one, even before becoming aware of the dual process model, that is an idea that has been ingrained in me as well as many other people. I have always felt like it is wise to stop and think when making decisions and that using system 1 when making decisions is more error prone. When I first came across the model in my economics module this was further reinforced. System 1 was framed as something that led to consumers acting irrationally.
I had internalised this way of thinking, I thought by taking time to think the situation through it would lead me to a rational, well thought out decision but instead all I did was delay in a situation that required quick thinking and put off what was the only option in this situation.

One of the main functions of system 2 is to control the urges of system 1 (Kanheman, 2011). System 1 is seen as error prone and that the use of system 2 is foolproof and will lead to decisions that have successful outcomes. Which is exactly what I felt in that moment, a need for a decision that was more thought out and a result would be the correct choice .

However I learned something during this semester's Strategic Thinking module that contextualised the dual process model for me. That system 1 is adequate in situations where there is a wealth of information and knowledge. In my case, I knew there was no way to get the bus with the lack of cash and a leap card which was my first instinct and my first instinct was correct.
The concept of there being a situation wherein system 1being adequate is something I have further researched as finding out when to rely on system 1 vs system 2 is something that interests me greatly.
As a result of this research I discovered that heuristics are not always rational and it depends on the environment (Gigerenzer, G. 2008). This applies to my case in the sense that the context required quick decision making and I already had the available knowledge and information to make that decision. I didn't gain any new knowledge or information in the 3 minutes I spent trying to come up with a solution.

From the module and the experience I've reflected on there has definitely been a shift in my mindset. Back in September I thought the only way to arrive at a good decision was a slow, deliberate process where you weigh out and evaluate all your options before you can then reach a decision. Now three months later, I understand that a measured and deliberate process is not always required to arrive at the best decision. In situations where the decision maker already has sufficient knowledge and information system 1 can be relied on. Situations with constraints such as time will require that quick decision making.

Going forward I want to strengthen my awareness of when to apply each system. For example, situations that are familiar to me won't require a slow and deliberate decision making process. This awareness can be done by studying the concept deeper, I have already

purchased the book “Thinking Fast and Slow” by Daniel Kahneman to read over the Christmas break

Reflection 2: Psychological Safety

I was not aware of the concept, “psychological safety” by name when I first came across it during the Strategic Thinking module. Although I was not aware of the concept by name, I have definitely felt the feeling of being in a psychologically safe environment. I have felt it in both my work and school environments. Team psychological safety is the belief that the team is safe for interpersonal risk-taking and this belief tends to be tacit. (Edmonson, 1999). These psychologically safe teams tend to be less successful because team members are in an environment where learning behaviors are present and they aren’t afraid to make mistakes and learn from those mistakes.

After I learned the academic definition of team psychological safety I began to reflect and think of environments and situations where this concept would apply. As an avid football fan, at the mention of the word “team” my mind did instantly go to football teams. Organisational work teams are groups that exist within the context of a larger organisation and have clearly defined membership, and share responsibility for a team product or service (Hackman, 1987; Alderfer, 1987;Edmondson, 1999). Meaning the concepts of work teams can be applied to football teams. The first team squad exists within the context of the larger football club and the players of the first team have defined membership through their contracts.
Applying the concept of team psychological safety to football teams made me wonder about different teams and the contrasting environments.

A team leader is an important influence on team psychological safety. If the leader is supportive, members are more likely to conclude that the team constitutes a safe environment. Alternatively, if team leaders act in authoritarian or punitive ways, team members may be reluctant to engage in the interpersonal (Edmondson,1996; Edmonson, 1999).

The best example I could think of for this was Chelsea vs Arsenal during the era of Arsene Wenger and Jose Mourinho. Arsene Wenger was a manager that appeared an extremely supportive leader, he emphasised player autonomy, the development of young players and risk taking during matches. The creativity and flair his arsenal team played with, indicated that there was a high tolerance for interpersonal risk which is a characteristic of a psychologically safe team.

On the other hand, Jose Mourinho is a manager that has a reputation for his teams being well disciplined and has himself publicly called players out for their mistakes multiple times over the course of his career and has been documented to have fallen out with football boards and players alike at multiple clubs such as chelsea, man united, real madrid etc. A manager who values short-term success over the long-term and team’s well-being. His authoritarian

approach tends to create an unsafe psychological environment, where players are afraid of taking risks.

Other than football terms, another environment I was able to apply the context of psychological safety to was my own work environment. At work we make and pack food for various airlines and flights taking off at Dublin airport. We have two production floors, one for economy and one for business class. Before I got moved to business class I had been working in economy for about two years with a team that was built up of other young adults like myself and teenagers aged 16 and above. I was the longest serving employee there and as a result became somewhat of an unofficial leader. Before that stage my workplace has always been an environment where employees have been able to admit errors and learn from, our supervisors and managers are extremely approachable and encourage us to admit mistakes and learn from them. We are also empowered to organise our work day the way we feel is most efficient. Each person is assigned to an airline at the start of each work day, (e.g Delta, American Airlines) and are given the responsibility to complete the orders by the end of the day.

Reflecting on my work environment with the knowledge that I now have, I can say with full confidence that it is an environment where team members feel psychologically safe. While at work I never feel anxious which is shocking to me because on my first day there I was more nervous than I had ever been before, but it's a testament to the environment that has been created. I also felt a sense of autonomy because we have been empowered to make decisions within certain boundaries.

When evaluating the examples of football teams and my own workplace experiences, it is clear to me that psychological safety plays a huge role in shaping performances and the development of a team. My workplace where learning behaviours were present led to open communication and learning from mistakes. Wenger's leadership at Arsenal encouraged creativity and risk taking, an environment that supported growth even though it did not guarantee success/immediate success. In contrast there is Mourinho's more authoritarian approach that although produces an environment that is not high on psychological safety but produces short term results at the cost of team-wellbeing and long-term stability.

Going forward there are certainly areas where I can apply this newfound knowledge in order to improve as a professional. About a month ago there was a high pressure situation at work. A flight order greatly increased in numbers just a few hours before the flight was supposed to take off. While we were updating the order one of my coworkers made a mistake with calculations and told me about it and I regrettably had a negative reaction to it. Team psychological safety facilitates learning behaviours so team members are confident enough to speak up with the knowledge that team members won't hold their errors against them Edmonson, 1999). With my negative reaction I could have potentially discouraged that coworker (who was relatively new to the job), from admitting errors in the future.

Fortunately I was able to reassure her after the incident because she felt comfortable enough to confront me about it later on.

So my action plan going forward is to be mindful that my actions and reactions could possibly dissuade people from speaking up and thus creating a psychological unsafe environment. I want to make an effort to pause before reacting, especially in high pressure situations.

Reflection 3: VR Experience

During the VR session on the 17th of November I played through two simulations. The first of the two was a roleplay where I played the part of a member of a team in a business organisation trying to convince the lead of our team that the data we had based our project on was faulty and put our entire project at risk. In the second roleplay I had to engage with my Human Resources manager to come up with a way to respond to a situation where the HR team had received feedback from employees working at a company. An overwhelming percentage of the feedback from the employees were positive, however two employees gave scathingly negative feedback about their experience at the company, which demanded attention.

For the first roleplay I had a feeling of inadequacy. Even though it was a roleplay I wanted to do well and this was measured by being able to convince my team lead that the data we based our project on was incorrect and put the project at risk. However I don't know a lot about faulty data so before the roleplay even started I already felt that it was going to be difficult to convince my team leader that the data we had based our project on was faulty enough to halt the project or even pause it and do something about said data. So my thinking for the roleplay was to use technical phrases such as "the prediction models we used were inaccurate" in order to convince my manager of the fault in our project.

As the roleplay went on I began to feel frustration because it seemed like nothing I said could convince my team lead that the issue I had brought up was a legitimate one. My team leader's focus was on making sure that the project went forward without any delays and unless I could explain the exact issue with the data then my issue was a non-issue. Which was a huge problem because I had no idea how to explain faulty data.

Fortunately a break through came when the team lead mentioned that we had used industry models on the the project and I was able to flip it by mentioning that we had not used all industry models and since it has already been revealed that time was a major factor I was able to reassure her that I would be able to confirm the accuracy of our data with the remaining

standard industry models we hadn't used before a deadline that would not delay the project from moving forward. Again, even though it was a role play I had a sense of accomplishment at being able to reach a positive conclusion.

I felt much more confident going into the second roleplay having just reached a positive conclusion in the first, I felt like I now knew how to interact with the avatars better. Maybe in my confidence I misunderstood the prompt for the second roleplay but the way I understood it was that we had to discuss how to handle the situation where two employees had had very negative experiences at the company in a review that had taken place. My thinking was that although most of the feedback was overwhelmingly positive each individual at the company should be heard and that their experience should not be diminished or overlooked. So my solution was to follow up with these employees in a way that they could share the specifics of their experience in an anonymous way so they would be more comfortable. With this solution I was able to reach a conclusion to the roleplay in about three minutes which was five minutes quicker than the first roleplay. The reason I felt like I misunderstood the prompt was because all the people I could hear around me were trying to convince their HR managers that 2 pieces of negative feedback were not a big deal and that they should not overshadow positive feedback, which is an approach I don't fully understand.

Overall the experience was really positive and it was interesting to get to interact with team leaders and members of management in that way. Even though I have a job, it's not one that requires me to interact with team leaders in such a way. Although the first roleplay did not start off the best. My first approach was extremely ineffective and due to that the conversation basically went around in circles for the first few minutes. I now realise that it was because I was so set on proving that the data was faulty and that technique was not working but I continued to insist on it when I should have switched techniques. The team leader in this roleplay from the beginning made it clear that her priority was making sure that the project was not delayed so I should have identified sooner and switched my approach sooner to offer a solution that fulfilled her wish of the project not being delayed. When I eventually did switch my approach I was ready to meet a conclusion quickly.

For the second roleplay my approach was much more effective and I was able to reach a conclusion without any pushback from the HR manager. Part of the reason I did so well was I grew accustomed to the AI avatars and had a sense of what they were looking for. The experience of the first roleplay was extremely helpful going into the second one.

From this experience I learned the importance of being adaptive, I had to be adaptive by modifying my approach during the first roleplay and my confidence in these sort of scenarios has been improved which could definitely be a benefit as I move forward with my professional career. I also learned that the importance of knowing what the other party's priority is, is an important part of any negotiation strategy.
My confusion at the second scenario will lead to a change in behaviour going forwards. If I ever get the opportunity to repeat this experience I would ask for clarification from the avatar, so I am 100% clear on the objectives of the meeting.

Going forward in similar situations like in scenario 1 where I need to negotiate or convince someone of something I will be sure to identify what the person values most to make an effort to align their goals with mine in order for smoother negotiations. I will also be mindful of being more flexible in my approaches, making sure to pivot when it is clear a certain approach does not appeal to the opposite party. Overall this experience has provided me with insights that I am sure will be extremely useful when I eventually get a corporate job.

Reflection 4: Strategic Thinking Tool and Techniques module

While I sat in that first Strategic Thinking Tools and Techniques lecture I wasn't really sure what to expect. My thoughts strayed to a Critical Thinking module I took during my second year of university and wondered if it would be similar. We were then told the objective of the module. Which is to develop students that make consequential decisions using analytical thinking and intuition.

As the semester progressed I was able to develop my critical thinking and my understanding of strategic thinking concepts. I was able to do so by attending the lectures, participating in the virtual reality sessions, completing the online courses, reading the articles put up on loop and by reflecting on events that took place in my own life with the new knowledge I had acquired.

Throughout the module I learned many concepts, the ones that stood out to me the most were the Dual process model and the concept of Psychological safety. These stood out to me the most because they influenced my way of thinking the most. Thanks to being introduced to the concept of psychological safety, I became more aware of how my behaviour affects my coworkers in the workplace and that my behavior is a reflection of how safe our workplace environment really is. Being introduced to the dual process theory made me reflect more on my thinking process than I ever have before and gave me the knowledge to identify when system 1 or system 2 is at work and to identify situations where each system is more proficient.

The lecture on group influences gave me a better understanding on group dynamics and was really helpful even in different modules where group work had been difficult. For example, the anecdote about leaders arising in groups where they are most needed really resonated with me and gave me the courage to take the lead for one of my group assignments.

Through the online “Introduction to Critical Thinking” course on Sage Campus I gained an understanding of how to construct and structure logical arguments and how to identify different components of an argument, while also exploring the role of heuristics, how to accurately identify the biases they cause, and the specific strategies required to mitigate them."

From the virtual reality sessions I had the opportunity to interact with members of organisation teams in ways I don’t have the opportunity to do at my current job. From these interactions I learned the importance of adaptive negotiation and identifying the priority of your counterpart and using it to reach a solution that suits both parties.

While these are all positives of the module there were challenges present also. The main one being the futures thinking project, which was very difficult in the beginning. We were introduced to futures thinking techniques that were to be used for the project, such as Horizon Planning, Drivers Wheel, Future Circle, Axes of uncertainty. Learning about how to use these techniques has been a great learning experience for me, but the issue for our group was that we had used these techniques on the town we had been assigned to but were struggling on how to use these techniques we had used to actually start writing the report. This is a challenge we faced for a while, it seemed like every meeting we had was just going in circles and we were making no progress past the initial techniques done. In addition to that this project is the last project due out of all other projects across our other modules. So it felt like all group members (myself included) were giving priority to other deadlines and assignments which made it difficult for the assignment to progress as well.

Thankfully over the last few weeks we seem to be making slow but steady progress. I am not one that usually likes to lead group discussions. However the dynamics of this group have really made me come out of my comfort zone, especially being the only Irish student in the group for an assignment that is based on the analysis of an Irish town. It makes me feel like my opinions hold more weight than they ever have before in a group project.

Reflecting on the module as a whole, the combination of theory, opportunities for reflection, VR sessions and this module has expanded my knowledge and equipped me with many useful skills that I will be able to in the future, such as being able to foster psychologically safe environments which is something I will be more mindful of as I continue with my professional career. Negotiating skills and interacting with leaders of organisations teams are also skills that I have acquired during this module that I will use in the future. Additionally I now know of biases such as anchoring bias, halo effect etc, I am now in a better position to identify when biases are clouding my judgement. Furthermore I am now better at understanding group dynamics which has been extremely beneficial for group assignments this semester and is an understanding that I will put to use for my group assignments during the upcoming semester.

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